An incident in 1583 in Fatehpur Sikri was further demonstration of the close bond between Akbar and Raja Birbal. During an elephant fight organized in the grounds of Akbar's court, one of the elephants, 'unique for violence', suddenly rushed towards Birbal, and seized him with his trunk. Akbar turned his horse around and galloped towards the elephant, charging at him, while all around him his soldiers and courtiers shouted out in alarm. The elephant then turned towards Akbar but, inexplicably, faltered, and Birbal was saved.

A few months later, the courtiers of Fatehpur Sikri were caught up in a much more joyous emotion. The young prince Salim, fifteen years old, was getting ready for his marriage and the prestige of the clan of the Kachhwahas was about to be burnished to high gold. 'Since (Man Singh) was constantly in my father's house,' wrote Jahangir later in his memoir, 'I myself proposed marriage with his sister', Rajkumari Man Bai. According to Abu'l Fazl, it was the Kachhwahas who desired this union as Raja Bhagwant Das 'had a daughter whose purity adorned her high extraction and was endowed with beauty and graces', and so the Kachhwahas wished that 'she should be united to the prince'. As for Badauni, it mattered little who first proposed the idea since it was all a highly regrettable habit 'in accordance with [Akbar's] established custom' to ally himself with the Hindus and raise them up at court.

And so on a cool day in February 1584, as the sun arced through the sky, the once insignificant town of Amer was about to be lit up with a magnificence it had never before witnessed. The Padshah of Hindustan, along with the leading qazis and nobles of the court, for the first time in the history of the Mughals, brought a baraat to the bride's home in Raja Bhagwant Das's palace. 'They performed all the ceremonies which are customary among the Hindus,' wrote Badauni, 'such as lighting the fire etc. and over the litter of the Princess the Emperor ordered gold to be scattered all the way from that house to the palace.' Raja Bhagwant Das gave a splendid dowry for his daughter, who would be renamed Sultan un-Nisa Begum. He gave 'several strings of horses, and a hundred elephants, and boys and girls of Abyssinia, India and Circassia, and all sorts of golden vessels set with jewels, and jewels, and utensils of gold and silver'. Akbar himself, it was noted, carried the bridal palanquin part of the way back. Nor were the noblemen ignored, for they were all gifted 'Persian, Turkish and Arabian horses with golden saddles'. And so another Rajput princess from